

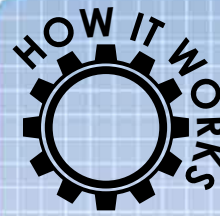
## Going around the bend

Deadly diseases, including cholera and typhoid, were **spread** because waste wasn't flushed away. In 1775, Scottish inventor **ALEXANDER CUMMINGS** came to the rescue with his toilet. His invention was an improvement on previous models because the pipe that took away the waste included an **S trap**, a double bend that stopped horrible fumes from finding their way back up the pipe. The toilet was a relief to everyone and his design became the prototype for future toilets.

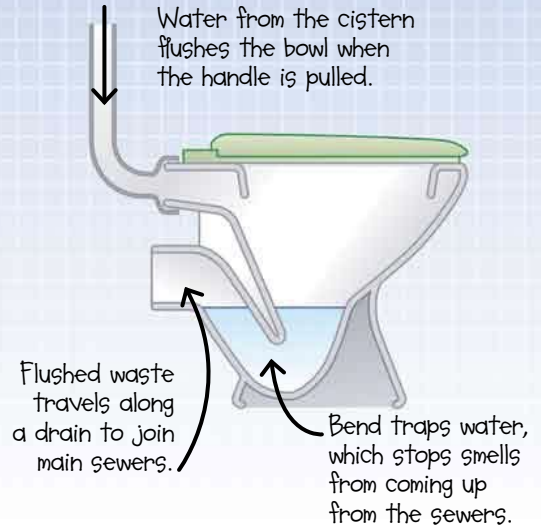


Invented in 1870 by Stevens Hellyer, the Optimus was an advanced toilet design, with an under-the-rim flushing mechanism that was much more effective than previous versions.

**Did you know?**  
Before toilet paper, people used moss or leaves. Rich people might have used cloth, such as wool or even lace.



Like Cummings's toilet, modern versions still use a bend to trap water, usually in a U shape. There have been some improvements, but the basic flush toilet design has stayed the same, whooshing water down a pipe to carry waste away.



**How it changed**

Diseases caused by sewage can kill. The flush toilet has done more to stop the spread of these diseases than any other invention—saving millions of lives.

**the world**



Toilets cleaned up their act with the arrival of **DISINFECTANTS**. Carbolic acid was in use from the 1860s to kill germs and improve cleanliness.



**PORTABLE TOILETS**, which use chemicals to deodorize waste, were invented in the 1940s for shipyard workers. They are still used at concerts and festivals.